

Business Management System

Design System & UI Standards

v1.1 — Reference for Stitch prompt design and UI standardization

Optimized for speed, information density, and clear navigational hierarchy in high-frequency retail operations (Kenyan SMEs).

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1. Introduction & Design Principles

This design system exists to standardize UI decisions across the Business Management System (BMS) so that every screen produced — whether hand-built or generated through Stitch — feels like part of one coherent product. It should be referenced directly when writing Stitch prompts: reuse the exact tokens, hex values, and component rules below rather than re-deriving them per screen.

BMS is used by owners and cashiers running live retail operations — often mid-transaction, with a customer waiting. The system optimizes for four things, in priority order:

- Speed & frictionless execution — every screen a cashier or owner touches repeatedly (POS checkout, stock lookup, daily reconciliation) should minimize clicks, keystrokes, and visual scanning time.
- Information density without clutter — the system handles large volumes of input and output (line items, inventory counts, sales figures) and must present dense data legibly, not sparsely.
- Clear navigation & hierarchy — with many pages and two distinct roles (owner, cashier), users must always know where they are, what matters most on the current screen, and how to get back.
- Semantic clarity through color — color is never decorative. It encodes status, urgency, and role-scoping consistently across the entire product.

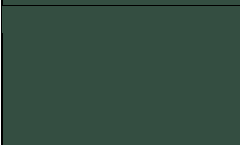
Visual reference points: Shopify Admin (data density with warmth), Linear (speed, keyboard-first interaction, restraint), QuickBooks (financial clarity, trustworthy enterprise tone).

Revision note (v1.1): the Success token was re-saturated and the status-pill pattern (Section 10.1) was made mandatory after review found the original Success color reading too close to neutral text in built screens — see Sections 2.2 and 10.1.

2. Color System

All color in BMS is semantic. Every hex value below has one job. Do not introduce new colors in Stitch prompts — reference these tokens by name.

2.1 Brand Colors

Swatch	Token / Hex	Usage
	Primary #344E41	Primary buttons, active nav item, key headings, brand marks. The dominant color of ownership and confidence.
	Secondary #A3B18A	Secondary buttons, subtle section fills, selected-but-not-primary states, chips on light surfaces.
	Accent #DDA15E	High-attention highlights: featured metrics, promotional callouts, and — paired with an icon — warning states. Use sparingly; it loses power if overused.
	Background #F7F4EC	App canvas background behind all cards and panels. Never used for text or icons.

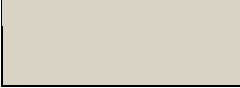
	Surface #FFFFFF	Cards, modals, panels, table rows — anything sitting above the background.
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2.2 Semantic Status Colors

Status colors are deliberately distinct from the brand palette so a success state is never mistaken for a primary action, and so color-blind users aren't relying on green-vs-green distinctions alone.

Swatch	Token / Hex	Usage
	Success #2E7D32	Completed transactions, positive stock levels, confirmations. Revised to a fully saturated green — an earlier, more muted draft of this token read too close to neutral text and failed to register as a distinct status at a glance. Always rendered as a tinted pill (see Section 10), never as bare colored text.
	Warning #DDA15E	Low stock, pending approval, expiring items. Always paired with a warning icon and explicit label text.
	Danger / Error #BC4749	Failed transactions, stockouts, destructive actions (delete, void sale), validation errors. Always paired with an icon.
	Info #577590	Neutral system notices, tips, informational banners. The one cool tone in an otherwise warm palette — reserved for calm, non-urgent messaging.

2.3 Neutral & Text Colors

Swatch	Token / Hex	Usage
	Text Primary #2B2B28	Body copy, headings, primary labels on light surfaces.
	Text Muted #6B6B63	Secondary labels, timestamps, placeholder text, disabled states.
	Border / Divider #D8D3C4	Card outlines, table row dividers, input borders at rest.

2.4 Usage Rules

- Never encode meaning in color alone — every status color pairs with an icon and/or text label (accessibility and speed: icons are scanned faster than color alone).
- Status text is never rendered as bare colored text directly on a white or background surface — low-saturation status colors can end up nearly indistinguishable from muted body text at that weight. Status is

always shown as a tinted pill: a light tint of the semantic color as background, with darker text/icon of the same hue on top (full spec in Section 10.1). This guarantees the status pops as a shape, not just a color.

- Primary green is reserved for actions and brand — never repurpose it for a 'success' toast; use the dedicated Success token so the two concepts stay visually distinct even though both are green-family.
- Warning and Accent share a token deliberately — both represent 'pay attention here,' just at different intensities (promotional vs. cautionary).
- Cashier-role screens should lean on Primary/Secondary/Surface almost exclusively; reserve Accent and status colors for moments that truly need interruption, since cashiers are optimizing for pure speed.

3. Typography

3.1 Typeface

Inter (or an equivalent geometric-humanist sans such as system UI fonts) across the entire product — matches the Shopify Admin / Linear reference points and renders legibly at small sizes in dense tables.

3.2 Type Scale

Style	Size / Line-height	Weight	Usage
Display	28 / 36px	Bold	Dashboard hero numbers (e.g. today's revenue)
H1	24 / 32px	Bold	Page titles
H2	19 / 28px	Semibold	Section headings within a page
H3	16 / 24px	Semibold	Card titles, table group headers
Body	14 / 20px	Regular	Default body copy, table cells, form values
Body Strong	14 / 20px	Semibold	Emphasized values — totals, quantities
Caption	12 / 16px	Regular	Timestamps, helper text, metadata
Label	12 / 16px	Semibold, uppercase, tracked	Form field labels, table column headers

4. Spacing & Layout Grid

4.1 Base Unit & Spacing Scale

4px base unit. All padding, margins, and gaps are multiples of 4, expressed as a fixed scale so Stitch prompts can reference a step name instead of a raw pixel value:

- space-1: 4px — icon-to-label gaps

- space-2: 8px — tight internal padding (chips, badges)
- space-3: 12px — form field internal padding
- space-4: 16px — default card padding, gaps between related fields
- space-6: 24px — gaps between form sections
- space-8: 32px — gaps between major page sections
- space-12: 48px — page-level top/bottom margins

4.2 Grid & Breakpoints

- Desktop / tablet (primary target for Owner Dashboard, Settings, back-office screens): 12-column grid, 24px gutters.
- POS Cashier Workspace: fixed two-pane layout (cart-dominant), not a fluid 12-column grid — optimized for the terminal form factor over general responsiveness.
- Mobile: single column, stacked cards, sticky primary action at the bottom of the viewport for one-thumb operation.

5. Elevation, Radius & Borders

5.1 Corner Radius

- radius-lg (12px): default for cards, panels, modals — the signature soft-enterprise rounding established for BMS.
- radius-md (8px): buttons, inputs, badges.
- radius-full (999px): pills, avatar containers, status dots.

5.2 Elevation (Shadow Levels)

- Level 0 — flat: default resting state for cards on the app background (a 1px Border token outline, no shadow, keeping the flat aesthetic).
- Level 1 — subtle lift: dropdowns, popovers (small soft shadow, ~4px blur).
- Level 2 — overlay: modals, command palette, confirmation dialogs (larger soft shadow, ~16px blur, dimmed backdrop).

The overall aesthetic stays flat and warm — shadows are used functionally (to signal 'this floats above the page'), not decoratively.

6. Navigation & Hierarchy

6.1 Global Structure

- Owner-facing back office: persistent left sidebar (organization → business → branch context switcher at top, primary nav below, account/profile at bottom) plus a top bar for search, notifications, and quick actions.
- Cashier POS Workspace: no persistent sidebar — the workspace is exclusive and full-screen, since cashiers only ever operate within it. Navigation chrome is intentionally minimized in favor of cart space.
- Active nav item uses the Primary color as a filled or left-border indicator — never rely on bold text alone to show current location.

6.2 Wayfinding

- Every back-office page has a page title (H1) plus a one-line description or breadcrumb trail directly beneath it.
- Breadcrumbs are used wherever a page is more than one level deep (e.g. Inventory > Branch: Westlands > Product: Cooking Oil 2L).
- Tabs are used for sibling views of the same entity (e.g. the four-tab User Profile: Profile, Security, Preferences, Activity) — never for unrelated destinations.

6.3 Role-Based Navigation Scoping

- Owners see the full navigation tree: dashboard, inventory, sales, reporting, CRM, settings, employee management.
- Cashiers see only what they need mid-shift: the POS workspace and, if permitted, a lightweight personal activity/shift view — the full owner nav tree is never exposed to a cashier session.
- This scoping is a navigation rule, not just a permissions rule — it should be visible in Stitch prompts as 'render only these nav items for this role,' not 'render everything, disabled.'

7. Data Display Patterns

7.1 Tables & Data Grids

- Column headers use the Label style (uppercase, tracked, muted) so they recede below the data itself.
- Numeric columns (quantities, prices, totals) are right-aligned; text columns are left-aligned — never centered, for fast vertical scanning.
- Row height is compact by default (dense mode) given the volume of SKUs and transactions typical for an SME; provide a 'comfortable' density toggle only where a page is browsed rather than scanned repeatedly.
- Zebra striping is avoided in favor of a single hairline Border token between rows — keeps the flat aesthetic and reduces visual noise at high density.
- Row-level status (e.g. low stock, void) is shown via a small semantic-colored dot or badge in a dedicated leading column, not by tinting the whole row.

7.2 Cards & Summary Stat Blocks

- Dashboard stat cards lead with the Display-style number, a short Label above it, and a small trend indicator (up/down arrow in Success/Danger) below — the number is always the largest thing on the card.
- Cards are ordered by decision-importance, not by data source — the metric an owner needs to act on first sits top-left.

7.3 Empty, Loading & Error States

- Every data view has a designed empty state (first-run guidance, not just blank space) and a designed error state (403/404/500), consistent with the error-state work already established for BMS.
- Loading states use skeleton placeholders shaped like the eventual content (table rows, card blocks) rather than a generic spinner, so layout doesn't jump on load.

8. Forms & Input (Speed-Optimized)

8.1 Input Standards

- Inputs use radius-md (8px), a 1px Border-token outline at rest, and switch to a Primary-colored 1.5–2px outline on focus — no color fill change, so dense forms don't flicker visually as focus moves.
- Labels sit above fields (not inline placeholders-as-labels), so a field's meaning is never lost once the user starts typing.
- Field order follows natural task order (e.g. scan/search → quantity → confirm), not alphabetical or database order.

8.2 Numeric & Quantity Entry

- Quantity fields are type-only — no plus/minus steppers — consistent with the POS cart pattern already established, since steppers cost more clicks than typing a number directly.
- Currency fields display the KES symbol as a fixed prefix outside the editable text, never as part of the typed value.

8.3 Validation & Inline Feedback

- Validation errors appear inline beneath the field in the Danger color with a short, specific message — never as a separate summary block the user has to cross-reference.
- Destructive or high-consequence actions (void sale, delete product, remove employee) always route through a confirmation dialog, consistent with the confirmation-dialog patterns already established.

9. Actions & Buttons

9.1 Button Hierarchy

- Primary — solid Primary-color fill, white text: one per view for the single most important action (e.g. Complete Sale).
- Secondary — Secondary-color or outlined Primary, used for supporting actions (e.g. Hold Cart, Add Note).
- Tertiary / Ghost — text-only, muted, for low-emphasis actions (e.g. Cancel).
- Destructive — Danger-color outline or fill, reserved exclusively for irreversible or high-consequence actions.

9.2 Keyboard-First Interaction

- Every frequent action in the POS workspace and command palette has a keyboard shortcut, surfaced as a small key-cap style hint next to the action label.
- An escape hatch (Esc key, or a clearly labeled Cancel/Back) is always available from any modal, dialog, or multi-step flow — never trap the user.

10. Feedback & Status Components

10.1 Status Pill Specification

This is the mandatory pattern for any status shown inline — table rows, cards, activity logs. It replaces any earlier pattern of plain colored text next to an outline icon, which tested as too low-contrast against neutral text to register as a distinct status at a glance.

Status	Pill Background	Text / Icon	Example
Success	#E6EFE6	#1E5120	Completed sale, backup succeeded, item in stock
Warning	#F6EEE2	#764B09	Low stock, pending approval, expiring soon
Danger	#F7E9E9	#7A2E2F	Failed transaction, stockout, void
Info	#EBEEF2	#394C5E	Neutral system notice

- Shape: radius-full (pill), small Label-style text (12px, semibold), filled icon at 14px leading the text with 4–6px gap.
- The pill's text/icon color is always the darker '800-equivalent' shade of the same hue as the background tint — never plain gray or black on a colored fill — so status reads as one cohesive colored shape rather than colored text floating on white.
- Do not use these tints for anything except status — a green-tinted pill must always mean 'success', never used decoratively elsewhere on the page.

10.2 Toasts & Banners

- Toasts: appear top-right, auto-dismiss for Success/Info, persist until dismissed for Warning/Danger, always include a filled icon matching the semantic color plus the status pill treatment for the headline word.
- Banners: full-width, used sparingly for account- or business-level notices (e.g. subscription expiring) rather than per-row concerns.

11. Iconography

- A single consistent icon set throughout (outline style, 1.5–2px stroke) — matching the flat, warm aesthetic rather than heavy filled icons.
- Icons are never the sole carrier of meaning for a critical action — always paired with a text label, except in dense toolbars where a tooltip provides the label on hover/long-press.

12. Accessibility & Escape Hatches

- Text/background contrast meets at least WCAG AA across all semantic and brand color pairings — verify Accent-on-white and Secondary-on-white in particular, as the lightest tokens in the palette.
- Every semantic color is reinforced with icon and/or text, never color alone (see Section 2.4).
- Every flow — onboarding, checkout, settings — has a visible way back or out at each step, consistent with the escape-hatch principle already established for BMS.

13. Using This System in Stitch

When writing Stitch prompts for new BMS screens, reference this document directly rather than re-describing the system each time. A reliable pattern:

- Open with the fixed style preamble: primary #344E41, secondary #A3B18A, accent #DDA15E, background #F7F4EC, white surface cards, 12px corner radius, flat warm enterprise aesthetic referencing Shopify Admin, Linear, and QuickBooks.
- State the role context (owner vs. cashier) so Stitch scopes navigation and information density correctly.
- Call out which semantic colors appear on the screen and why (e.g. 'low-stock badges in Warning, void-sale button in Danger').
- Keep prompts split into focused passes for complex screens — this has already proven effective for BMS (e.g. Settings split across two passes) and keeps Stitch's output aligned to one section of this system at a time.

Treat this document as living — update the token tables here first whenever a new pattern is validated in Stitch, then propagate the change forward into future prompts, rather than letting screens drift apart from each other.